



What should I believe?

If you think about it, our initial question really breaks down into two sub-questions.

When should I form a  
new belief?

When should I discard  
one of my beliefs?

**Positive** rules of belief will tell you  
when you should form a certain  
belief.

If you are in such-and-such  
circumstances, you should  
believe P.

Negative rules of belief will tell you  
when you should not have a certain  
belief.



If you are in such-and-such  
circumstances, you should not  
believe P.

It might at first seem extremely easy to formulate the rules of belief. The following would seem to be plausible candidates, respectively, for positive and negative rules of belief.

If  $P$  is true, you should  
believe  $P$ .

If  $P$  is not true, you should  
not believe  $P$ .

The problem with these rules of belief is not that they are incorrect; the problem is that in many cases they won't be of much practical use, since in many cases we don't know for sure whether the claim in question is true or false. (If we did, there would be no serious question about whether to form the belief.)

TRUTH → BELIEF

NO TRUTH → NO BELIEF

Let's start with what looks like a pretty good candidate to be a positive rule of belief. This rule says that, if you can give a good argument for something, you should believe it.



Well, what's a good argument?

Part of the answer is that a good argument should be valid.

But that's not demanding enough; there are plenty of valid arguments whose conclusions you should not believe. After all, some valid arguments have obviously false premises.

Here's a possible answer. Maybe you should **only** believe things that you have a good argument for. This suggests a negative rule of belief:

No Good Argument  $\rightarrow$  No Belief

If you can't give a good  
argument for P, don't believe P.

Something like this idea lies behind the thought that we can demand that someone give a proof for something they believe. The idea is that without a proof — which is just a kind of argument — we should not believe.

The problem is that it is very hard to see how you could give good arguments for all of your beliefs.

Suppose that you try to give a good argument that some belief of yours is true. The argument is going to involve some premises.





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We'll be trying, for the next three classes, to improve upon these two rules

by trying to formulate rules of belief which we could actually put to use.



machine for generating hardware! Haven't yet already seen lots of cases

Why would we want to do this? Well, face cases where it is not clear

what we should believe. In fact, you might think, philosophy is a kind of

in which there are arguments on both sides of an issue, and where it is

hard to tell which argument is better?



Here is a hard case of interest:



all face objects that I can not see how to

this claim. But now I wonder whether I have

answer. Still, I continue to believe that God

I've always believed that there is a God. I never

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arguments for God's existence and god, but



good reason for my beliefs. Some of the

exits.

really thought about what my evidence is for

but what the rules of belief are.

it is hard to see how to figure it out other than by trying to figure

It is genuinely hard to know what to do in this kind of situation. And

Today we're going to focus on the question,





When should I discard

one of my beliefs?

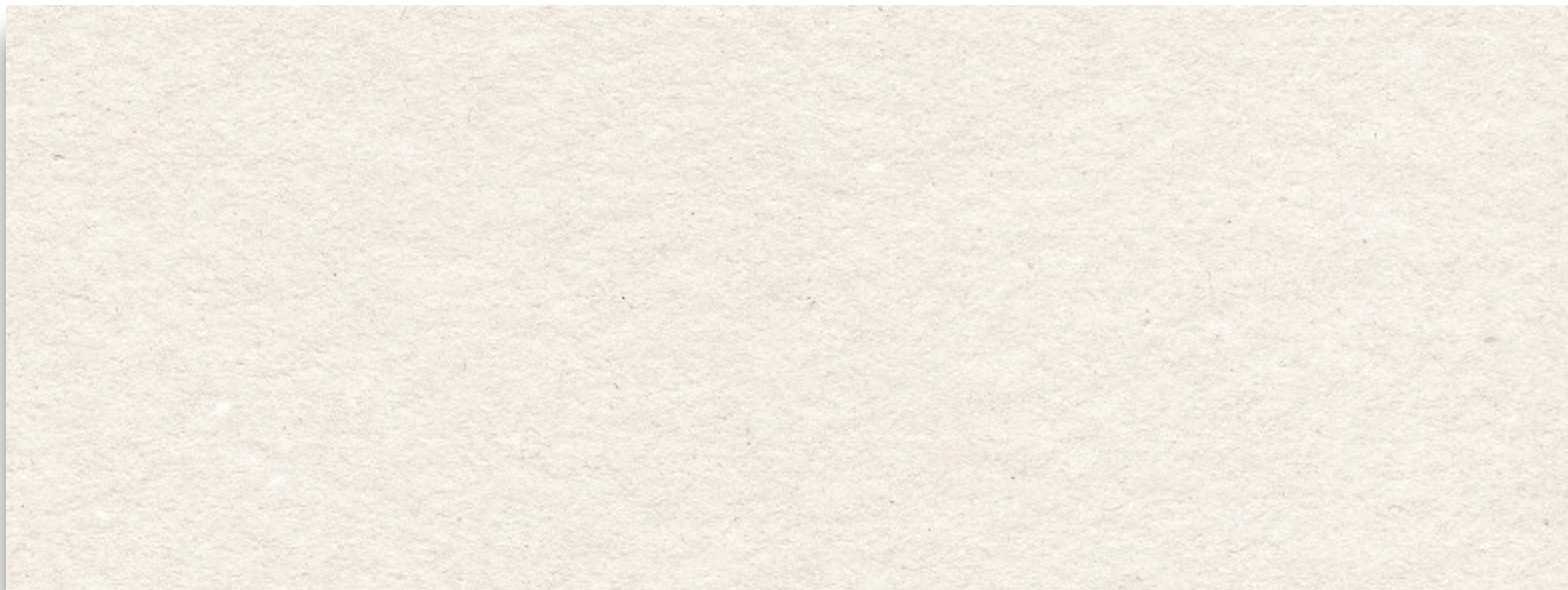
people face it in an especially sharp way at exactly the age you are now.

Going to college, where you encounter new ideas and new people, is a natural

bedrive.

This is a question which most people face at some point in their lives. Often,

time to wonder whether you still really accept the views that you used to





failures which I had accepted as true in my

childhood, and by the highly influential nature of the

while I did not have any basis for that.

'Some years ago I was struck by the large number of

Realized that it was necessary, once in the course

# 11kely to last. ; ;

east abolish anything at all that was stable and

stair again right from the foundation if I wanted to



of my life, to deny I wish every thing I could let go and

Descartes gave a famous statement of this idea:

forming even one belief which you should not form is likely to lead to a

whole series of mistakes.

typically combines with your other beliefs to give you yet more beliefs. So

Your system of beliefs is like a web. Once you form a new belief, that belief

you're beliefs once you're an adult, and see if there are any that you should

discard.



De Santis' thought is that the only way to fix this situation is to re-examine

That leads to the question: what rule should you use to tell you which to

discard?

Here again Descartes gives us an answer.



assent from persons which are not completely certain and

indubitably just as I do from those which

patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinion,



'Reason now leads me to believe that I should back my

it will be enough if I find in each of them one reason for

old world + .99

What would it mean for you to find in some belief a reason for doubt?

that certain things are true. But what we can be certain



It seems that to find a reason for doubting a belief would be less

we can prove. This suggests the following rule of belief:



One natural thought is that we can be certain only of those things that



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